

Visitor Visa

Overview

Generally, a citizen of a foreign country who wishes to travel to the United States must first obtain a visa, either a nonimmigrant visa for a temporary stay, or an immigrant visa for permanent residence. Visitor visas are nonimmigrant visas for persons who want to enter the United States temporarily for business (B-1 visa), for tourism (B-2 visa), or for a combination of both purposes (B-1/B-2 visa).

Here are some examples of activities permitted with a visitor visa:

Business (B-1)

- Consult with business associates
- Attend a scientific, educational, professional, or business convention or conference
- Settle an estate
- Negotiate a contract

Tourism (B-2)

- Tourism
- Vacation (holiday)
- Visit with friends or relatives
- Medical treatment
- Participation in social events hosted by fraternal, social, or service organizations
- Participation by amateurs in musical, sports, or similar events or contests, if not being paid for participating
- Enrollment in a short recreational course of study, not for credit toward a degree (for example, a two-day cooking class while on vacation)

Travel Purposes Not Permitted On Visitor Visas

These are some examples of activities that require different categories of visas and cannot be done while on a visitor visa:

- Study
- Employment
- Paid performances, or any professional performance before a paying audience
- Arrival as a crewmember on a ship or aircraft
- Work as foreign press, in radio, film, print journalism, or other information media
- Permanent residence in the United States

Birth tourism (travel for the primary purpose of giving birth in the United States to obtain U.S. citizenship for their child) is not permissible on a visitor visa.

How to Apply

There are several steps to apply for a visa. The order of these steps and how you complete them may vary by U.S. Embassy or Consulate. Please consult the instructions on the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate website](#).

Complete the Online Visa Application

- **Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#)** – [Learn more](#) about completing the [DS-160](#). You must: 1) complete the online visa application and 2) print the application form confirmation page to bring to your interview.
- **Photo** – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. Your photo must meet the [Photograph Requirements](#).

Schedule an Interview

Interviews are generally required for visa applicants with certain limited exceptions. Consular officers may require an interview of any visa applicant.

You should generally schedule an appointment for your visa interview at the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) in the country where you live. You may schedule your interview at another U.S. Embassy or Consulate where you will be present but aware that in some cases it may be more difficult to demonstrate your qualifications for a visa outside of the country where you live.

Wait times for interview appointments vary by location, season, and visa category, so you should apply for your visa early. Review the interview wait time for the location where you will apply:

Prepare for Your Interview

- **Fees - Pay the non-refundable visa application fee**, if you are required to pay it before your interview. If your visa is approved, you may also need to pay a visa issuance fee, if applicable to your nationality. Fee information is provided below:
\$185
- Review the instructions available on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) where you will apply to learn more about fee payment.

Gather Required Documentation

Gather and prepare the following required documents before your visa interview:

- **Passport** valid for travel to the United States – Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your period of stay in the United States (unless exempt by [country-specific agreements](#)). Each individual who needs a visa must submit a separate application, including any family members listed in your passport.
- **Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#) confirmation page.**
- **Application fee payment receipt**, if you are required to pay before your interview.
- **Photo** – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. If the [photo upload fails](#), you must bring one printed photo in the format explained in the [Photograph Requirements](#).

Additional Documentation May Be Required

Review the instructions for how to apply for a visa on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) where you will apply. Additional documents may be requested to establish if you are qualified. For example, additional requested documents may include evidence of:

- The purpose of your trip,
- Your intent to depart the United States after your trip, and/or
- Your ability to pay all costs of the trip.

Evidence of your employment and/or your family ties may be sufficient to show the purpose of your trip and your intent to return to your home country. If you cannot cover

all the costs for your trip, you may show evidence that another person will cover some or all costs for your trip.

Note: Visa applicants must qualify based on their ties abroad/to their home country, rather than assurances from U.S. family and friends. A letter of invitation or Affidavit of Support is not needed to apply for a visitor visa. If you choose to bring a letter of invitation or Affidavit of Support to your interview, please remember it is not one of the factors used in determining whether to issue or deny the visa.

Attend Your Visa Interview

A consular officer will interview you to determine whether you are qualified to receive a visitor visa. You must establish that you meet the requirements under U.S. law to receive a visa. Ink-free, digital fingerprint scans are taken as part of the application process. They are usually taken during your interview, but this varies based on location.

After your visa interview, the consular officer may determine that your application requires further [administrative processing](#). The consular officer will inform you if this required.

After the visa is approved, you may need to pay a visa issuance fee (if applicable to your nationality), and make arrangements for the return of the passport and visa to you. Review the [visa processing times](#) to learn more.

Entering the United States

A visa allows a foreign citizen to travel to a U.S. port-of-entry (generally an airport) and request permission to enter the United States. A visa does not guarantee entry into the United States. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials at the port-of-entry have authority to permit or deny admission to the United States. If you are allowed to enter the United States, the CBP official will provide an admission stamp or a paper Form I-94, Arrival/Departure Record. Learn more about admissions and entry requirements, restrictions about bringing food, agricultural products, and other restricted/prohibited goods, and more by reviewing the [CBP website](#).

Extending Your Stay

See [Extend Your Stay](#) on the U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) website to learn about requesting to extend your stay beyond the date indicated on your admission stamp or paper Form I-94.

Failure to depart the United States on time will result in being [out of status](#). Under U.S. law, visas of individuals who are out of status are automatically voided ([Section 222\(g\) of the Immigration and Nationality Act](#)). Any multiple entry visa that was voided due to being out of status will not be valid for future entries into the United States.

Failure to depart the United States on time may also result in you being ineligible for visas in the future. Review [Visa Denials](#) and [Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws](#) to learn more.

Change of Status

If your plans change while in the United States (for example, you marry a U.S. citizen or receive an offer of employment), you may be able to request a change in your nonimmigrant status to another category through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). See [Change My Nonimmigrant Status](#) on the USCIS website to learn more.

While you are in the United States, receiving a change of status from USCIS does not require you to apply for a new visa. However, once you depart the United States you must apply for a new visa at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate in the appropriate category for your travel.

Additional Information

- An individual on a visitor visa (B1/B2) is not permitted to accept employment or work in the United States.
- There is no guarantee you will be issued a visa. Do not make final travel plans or buy tickets until you have a visa.
- A valid U.S. visa in an expired passport is still valid. Unless canceled or revoked, a visa is valid until its expiration date. If you have a valid visa in your expired passport, do not remove it from your expired passport. You may use your valid visa in your expired passport along with a new valid passport for travel and admission to the United States.

[Travel for Medical Treatment](#)

If you are seeking medical treatment in the United States, the consular officer may ask for further documents at your visa interview, which may include:

- Medical diagnosis from a local physician, explaining the nature of the ailment and the reason you need treatment in the United States.
- Letter from a physician or medical facility in the United States, stating they are willing to treat your specific ailment and detailing the projected length and cost of treatment (including doctors' fees, hospitalization fees, and all medical-related expenses).

- Proof that your transportation, medical, and living expenses in the United States will be paid. This may be in the form of bank or other statements of income/savings or certified copies of income tax returns (either yours or the person or organization paying for your treatment).

Visitor Visas for Personal or Domestic Employees (B-1)

You may apply for a B-1 visitor visa to work in the United States as a personal or domestic employee for your employer in limited situations. You may for a visitor visa as a domestic employee if, among other requirements, your employer is:

- A U.S. citizen who has a permanent home or is stationed in a foreign country, but is visiting or is assigned to the United States temporarily; or
- A foreign citizen who is in the United States on one of the following nonimmigrant visa categories: B, E, F, H, I, J, L, M, O, P, Q or TN.

Learn more about your rights in the United States and protection available to you by reading the [Legal Rights and Protections](#) pamphlet.

Visa Renewal

Whether you are applying for the first time or renewing your visa, you will use the same application process (please review [How to Apply](#), above). Some applicants seeking to renew their visas in certain visa classes may be eligible for the Interview Waiver (IW) which allows qualified individuals to apply for visa renewals without being interviewed in person by a U.S. consular officer. Review the instructions on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) where you will apply to determine if IW is available and if you qualify.

Do I need a visa if I have an ABTC?

Yes, you will still need a visa to travel to the United States, unless you qualify for the [Visa Waiver Program](#). Having an Asian-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Business Travelers Card (ABTC) does not change visa requirements, your visa status, or the visa process for travel to the United States.

How can I use my ABTC when I apply for my visa?

If you have an Asian-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Business Travelers Card (ABTC), you might be able to schedule an expedited visa interview appointment. Review the instructions for scheduling expedited appointments on the website of the [embassy or consulate](#) where you will apply.

Visa Annotations for Certain Maritime Industry Workers

Certain foreign maritime workers are eligible to apply for a Transportation Worker Identification Credential (TWIC) once in the U.S. If you, as a maritime industry worker, will perform services in secure port areas, your visa must be annotated "TWIC Letter Received." Workers whose visas are not annotated will not be permitted by the Transportation Security Administration (TSA) to apply for a TWIC.

In order for your visa to be annotated, you must obtain a letter from your employer explaining the need for a TWIC and that you are a potential TWIC applicant. See a [template example](#) of this letter. You must present this letter when you apply for the B-1 visa. You must meet all other eligibility requirements for a B-1 visa.

Complete information about the TWIC program is available on TSA's website at <https://www.tsa.gov/for-industry/twic>.

Visa Denial and Ineligibility

Review [Visa Denials](#) for detailed information about visa ineligibilities, denials and waivers.

I was refused a visa, under Section 214(b). May I reapply?

Yes, if you feel circumstances have changed regarding your application. Review [Visa Denials](#) to learn more.

Misrepresentation or Fraud

Attempting to obtain a visa by the willful misrepresentation of a material fact, or fraud, may result in the permanent refusal of a visa or denial of entry into the United States.

Review [Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws](#).

Citizens of Canada and Bermuda

Citizens of Canada and Bermuda generally do not require visas to enter the United States, for visit, tourism and temporary business travel purposes. For more information see [U.S. Embassy Ottawa website](#), [U.S. Consulate Hamilton website](#) and [CBP website](#).

Additional resources for Canadian visitors to the United States can be found on the U.S. Embassy and Consulate websites in Canada.

Citizens of China

In accordance with the agreement signed between the United States and China to extend visa validity, as of November 29, 2016, Chinese citizens with 10-year B1, B2 or B1/B2 visas in Peoples' Republic of China passports will be required to update their biographical and other information from their visa application via a website every two years, or upon getting a new passport or B1, B2, or B1/B2 visa, whichever occurs first. This mechanism is called EVUS - Electronic Visa Update System.

The EVUS website is now open to the public for enrollments at [www.EVUS.gov](http://www.evus.gov). As of September 30, 2025, there is a \$30.00 fee charged for each new enrollment payable through the <http://www.evus.gov> website.

Citizens of Mexico

Citizens and permanent residents of Mexico generally must have a nonimmigrant visa or Border Crossing Card (also known as a "Laser Visa"). For ease of travel, the B-1/B-2 and the Border Crossing Card have been combined into one document (DSP-150).

Select [Border Crossing Card](#) to learn more about this card.

Please visit [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) websites for more information regarding applying for a visa at the U.S. Embassy or Consulates in Mexico.

[Further Questions](#)

- Case-Specific Questions - Contact the U.S. Embassy or Consulate handling your visa application for status information. Select [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) for contact information.
- General Questions - review [Contact Us](#).

Student Visa

Overview

Generally, foreign nationals who wish to travel to the United States must first obtain a visa, either a nonimmigrant visa for a temporary stay, or an immigrant visa for permanent residence. You must have a student visa to travel to the United States to study. Your course of study and the type of school you plan to attend determine whether you need an F visa or an M visa.

To enter the United States to attend:	You need the following visa category:
University or college	F
High School	
Private elementary school	
Seminary	
Conservatory	
Another academic institution, including a language training program	M
Vocational or other recognized nonacademic institution, other than a language training program	

Students cannot travel on the Visa Waiver Program or with Visitor Visas

You must have a student visa (F or M visa) to travel to the United States to study. You may not study after entering on a visitor (B) visa, unless you are eligible for and have obtained a change of status from USCIS, or through the Visa Waiver Program (VWP), except to undertake recreational (non-credit) study as part of a tourist visit. For more information on the VWP, see [Visa Waiver Program](#).

For short periods of recreational study, a Visitor (B) visa may be appropriate

A visitor (B) visa permits enrollment in a short recreational course of study, which is not for

credit toward a degree or academic certificate. Learn more about [Visitor Visas](#).

Study leading to a U.S. conferred degree or certificate is not permitted on a visitor (B) visa, even if it is for a short duration. For example, a student in a distance learning program that requires a period of time on the institution's U.S. campus must obtain a student (F or M) visa prior to entering the United States.

Student Acceptance at a SEVP Approved School

The first step to studying in the United States is apply to a SEVP-approved school in the United States. If the SEVP-approved school accepts your enrollment, you will be registered for the [Student and Exchange Visitor Information System \(SEVIS\)](#) and must pay the SEVIS I-901 fee. The SEVP-approved school will issue you a Form I-20. After you receive the Form I-20 and register in SEVIS, you may apply at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate for a student (F or M) visa. You must present the Form I-20 to the consular officer when you attend your visa interview.

If your spouse and/or children will live with you in the United States while you study, they must also enroll in SEVIS, obtain individual Form I-20s from the SEVP-approved school, and apply for a visa (but they do not pay the SEVIS fee).

Visit the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) [Student and Exchange Visitor Program \(SEVP\)](#) website to learn more about SEVIS and the SEVIS I-901 Fee.

Visit the Department of State [EducationUSA](#) website to learn about educational opportunities for undergraduate and graduate study, and an overview of the application process. You can also visit the DHS [Study in the States](#) school search page to search for SEVP-certified schools.

How To Apply

There are several steps to apply for a visa. The order of these steps and how you complete them may vary by U.S. Embassy or Consulate. Please consult the instructions on the [embassy or consulate website](#).

Complete the Online Visa Application

- **Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application, Form DS-160** – [Learn more](#) about completing the [DS-160](#). You must: 1) complete the online visa application, and 2) print the application form confirmation page to bring to your interview.
- **Photo** –You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. Your photo must meet the [Photograph Requirements](#).

Schedule an Interview

Interviews are generally required for visa applicants with certain limited exceptions. Consular officers may require an interview of any visa applicant.

You should schedule an appointment for your visa interview at the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) in the country where you live. You may schedule your interview at another U.S. Embassy or Consulate, but be aware that it may be more difficult to demonstrate that you qualify for a visa outside of the country where you live.

Wait times for interview appointments vary by location, season, and visa category, so you should apply for your visa early. Review the interview wait time for the location where you will apply:

New Students – Student (F and M) visas for new students can be issued up to 365 days before the start date of a course of study. However, you will not be allowed to enter the United States on your student visa more than 30 days before the start date.

Continuing Students - Student (F and M) visas for continuing students may be issued at any time, as long as the student is currently enrolled at a SEVP-approved school or institution and in SEVIS. Continuing students may enter the United States at any time before classes start.

Prepare for Your Interview

- **Fees - Pay the non-refundable visa application fee**, if you are required to pay it before your interview. If your visa is approved, you may also pay a visa issuance fee, if applicable to your nationality.
- Review the instructions available on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) where you will apply to learn more about fee payment.

Gather Required Documentation

Gather and prepare the following required documents before your visa interview:

- **Passport** valid for travel to the United States – Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your period of stay in the United States (unless exempt by [country-specific agreements](#)). Each individual who needs a visa must submit a separate application, including any family members listed in your passport.
- **Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#) confirmation page.**
- **Application fee payment receipt**, if you are required to pay before your interview.
- **Photo** – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. If the [photo upload fails](#), you must bring one printed photo in the format explained in the [Photograph Requirements](#).
- **Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (F-1) Student Status-For Academic and Language Students, Form I-20 or Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (M-1) Student Status for Vocational Students, Form I-20** – Your school will send you a Form I-20 once they have entered your information in the SEVIS database. You and your school official must sign the Form I-20. All students must be registered in the Student and Exchange Visitor System (SEVIS). Your spouse and/or minor children, if they intend live in the United States with you, will each receive an individual Form I-20.

Additional Documentation May Be Required

A consular officer will interview you to determine your qualifications for a student visa, and may request additional documents, such as evidence of:

- Your academic preparation, such as:
 - Transcripts, diplomas, degrees, or certificates from schools you attended; and
 - Standardized test scores required by your U.S. school;
- Your intent to depart the United States upon completion of the course of study; and
- How you will pay all educational, living and travel costs.

Review the instructions for how to apply for a visa on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or](#)

[Consulate](#) where you will apply.

Attend Your Visa Interview

A consular officer will interview you to determine whether you are qualified to receive a student visa. You must establish that you meet the requirements under U.S. law to receive a visa.

Ink-free, digital fingerprint scans are taken as part of the application process. They are usually taken during your interview, but this varies based on location.

After your visa interview, the consular officer may determine that your application requires further [administrative processing](#). The consular officer will inform you if this is required.

After the visa is approved, you may need to pay a visa issuance fee (if applicable to your nationality), and make arrangements for the return of the passport and visa to you. Review the [visa processing times](#) to learn more.

Entering the United States

A visa does not guarantee entry into the United States. A visa only allows a foreign citizen to travel to a U.S. port-of-entry (generally an airport) and request permission to enter the United States. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials at the port-of-entry have authority to permit or deny admission to the United States.

After you present your passport, visa, and Form I-20 at the port-of-entry, a CBP official will make this decision. Upon admission, the CBP official will provide an admission stamp or paper Form I-94, Arrival/Departure Record.

Learn about procedures for students (with F or M visas) entering the United States on the CBP website under [Arrival Procedures for Students or Exchange Visitors](#). Learn about admissions and entry requirements, restrictions about bringing food, agricultural products, and other restricted/prohibited goods, and more by reviewing the [CBP website](#).

Extending Your Stay

Foreign students in the United States with F visas must depart the United States within 60 days after the program end date listed on Form I-20, including any authorized practical training.

Foreign students may request an extension through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) website (see the USCIS [Extend Your Stay](#) page). Additional information to maintain student status is on the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement SEVP website under [Maintaining Your Immigration Status While a Student or Exchange Visitor](#).

Failure to depart the United States on time will result in being [out of status](#). Under U.S. law, visas of individuals who are out of status are automatically voided ([Section 222\(g\) of the Immigration and Nationality Act](#)). Any multiple entry visa that was voided due to being out of status will not be valid for future entries into the United States.

Failure to depart the United States on time may also result in you being ineligible for visas in the future in certain cases. Review [Visa Denials](#) and [Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws](#) to learn more.

Change of Status

If your plans change while in the United States (for example, you marry a U.S. citizen or receive an offer of employment), you may be able to request a change in your nonimmigrant

status to another category through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). See [Change My Nonimmigrant Status](#) on the USCIS website to learn more.

While you are in the United States, receiving a change of status from USCIS does not require you to apply for a new visa. However, once you depart the United States you must apply for a new visa at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate in the appropriate category for your travel.

Additional Information

- There is no guarantee you will be issued a visa. Do not make final travel plans or buy tickets until you have a visa.
- For information about working in the United States during your study, review [Students and Employment](#) and Form I-765 [Work Authorization Instructions](#) on the USCIS website.
- If you have a temporary break in your study, view the information on the SEVP website under [Do Students Returning from Temporary Absences Need New Visas?](#) If your student visa is still valid, but you are outside the United States, you should consult with your Designated School Officials.
- Spouse and children
 - Your spouse and unmarried, minor children who intend to reside with you during your study may apply for F-2 or M-2 visas. Although SEVIS fee payment is not required, your school must issue them an individual Form I-20, which is required to apply for their visas. You must provide a copy of your F-1 or M-1 visa and provide proof of relationship.
 - Your minor children are permitted to attend school in the United States while accompanying you.
 - U.S. Embassies and Consulates adjudicate visa applications for same-sex spouses in the same way that we adjudicate applications for opposite sex spouses.
- A valid U.S. visa in an expired passport is still valid. Unless canceled or revoked, a visa is valid until its expiration date. If you have a valid visa in your expired passport, do not remove it from your expired passport. You may use your valid visa in your expired passport along with a new valid passport for travel and admission to the United States.

Can I enter the United States more than 30 days in advance?

- Students on F or M visas are not permitted to enter the United States earlier than 30 days before the start date of their program. If you wish to enter earlier than 30 days before your start date, you must separately apply and qualify for a visitor (B) visa.
- After you are admitted to the United States by U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials in visitor (B) visa status, you must separately apply to U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) for a [change of status](#) to student (For M) status prior to the start of your program. You may not begin your course of study until the change of status is approved, and you may

encounter lengthy processing times. You may also depart the United States and re-enter on your student (F or M) visa.

Optional Practical Training

- Students who are authorized Optional Practical Training (OPT) must have a Form I-20 endorsed for OPT and must apply to USCIS for an Employment Authorization Document (EAD). OPT is temporary employment that is directly related to the eligible F-1 student's area of study. To learn more about OPT, please visit the [USCIS Website](#) and the [ICE International Students](#) webpage.

Attending Public Secondary School

There are restrictions on students in F-1 nonimmigrant status attending public school in the United States. See Foreign Students in Public Schools to learn more.

Visa Renewal

Whether you are applying for the first time or renewing your visa, you will use the same application process (please review How to Apply, above).

Visa Denial and Ineligibility

Review Visa Denials for detailed information about visa ineligibilities, denials, and waivers.

I was refused a visa under section 214(b). May I reapply?

You may reapply if you believe you have additional evidence of your qualifications for a student (F or M) visa, or you believe your circumstances have changed. Review Visa Denials to learn more.

Misrepresentation or Fraud

Attempting to obtain a visa by the willful misrepresentation of a material fact, or fraud, may result in the permanent refusal of a visa or denial of entry into the United States.

Review Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws.

Citizens of Canada and Bermuda

Citizens of Canada and Bermuda generally do not require visas to enter the United States as students, although they must present a valid Form I-20 at the time of admission. For more information see information for Citizens of Canada and Bermuda.

Additional resources for Canadian visitors to the United States can be found on the U.S. Embassy and Consulate websites in Canada.